

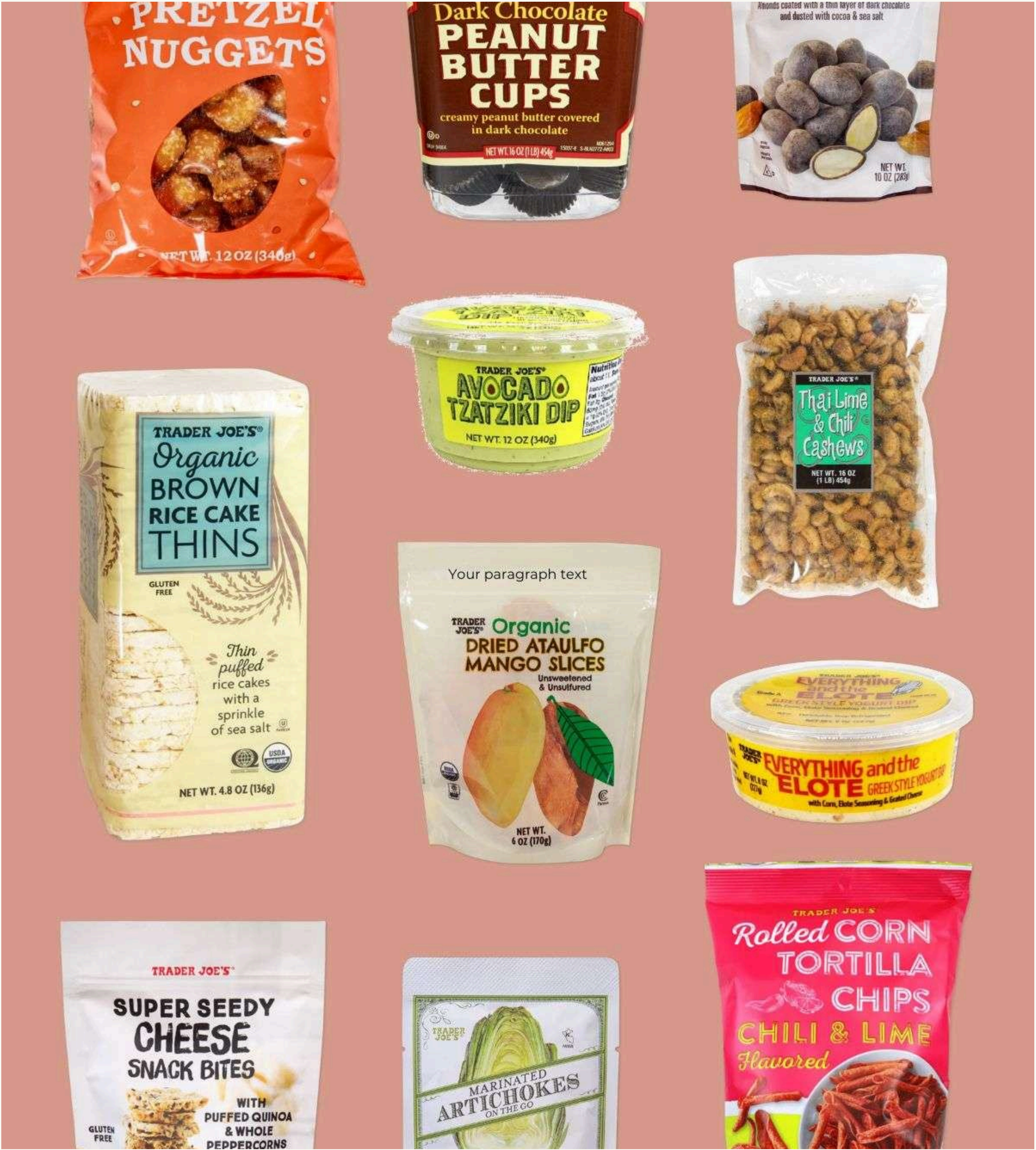
Trader Joe's Experience Research

GRID 5802 Design Research: Discovery Final Project
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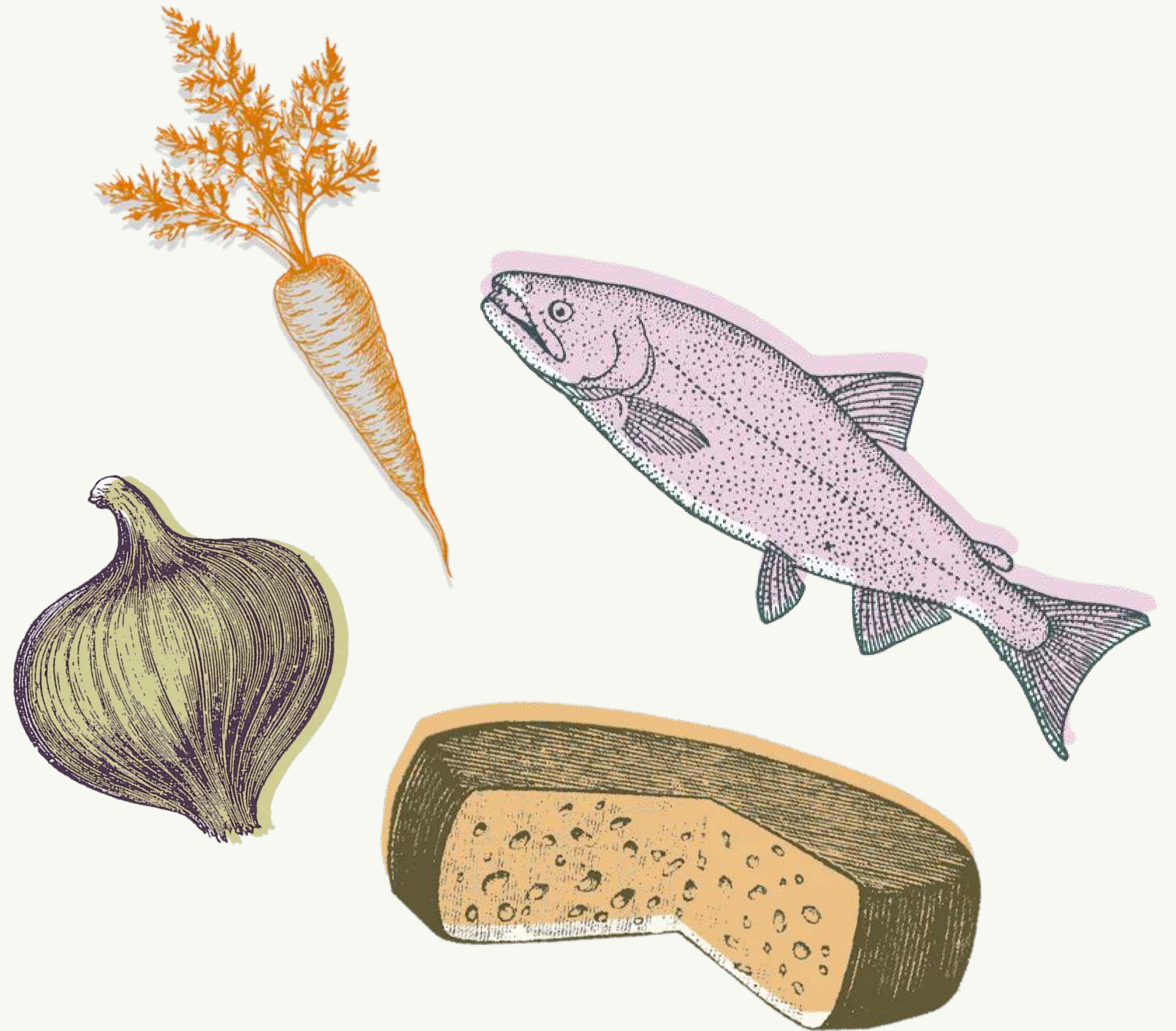


Problem/Opportunity Space

Although grocery shopping is a seemingly simple and regular task, there are ways the in-store and online shopping experience can be improved and optimized for the customer. In this research, we will focus on the experience of Trader Joe's shoppers and develop an understanding of customer needs and pain points during the grocery shopping process in order to define some opportunity spaces.



Research Plan



Research Objectives & Secondary Research

Objectives

Learning Goals

- What does Trader Joe's offer in terms of products and services?
- What are some strengths of Trader Joe's and what attracts customers?
- What are some pain points within the shopping experience?
- Can a digital avenue help increase interest in Trader Joe's (such as an app or online ordering)?
- Can a membership increase interest in Trader Joe's?

Secondary Research

Trader Joe's was made for college students who were well educated but did not have a high income. Trader Joe's wanted a fair priced option for this demographic and created this space by eliminating a middleman.

Trader Joe's mostly sells products of its own brand. They do not have an app, nor can you order online, nor can you order through Uber Eats or DoorDash. There is no membership card for Trader Joe's.

Research Methodology & Interview Guide

Methodology

5 participants executed the following:

- Interviews before shopping
- Shadowing website navigation
- Shadowing shopping

Interview Guide

1. Interview Guide

- a. Shopping habits
- b. Trader Joe's shopping experience
- c. Trader Joe's brand
- d. Trader Joe's membership or app
- e. Trader Joe's website
- f. Wrap up

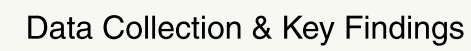
2. Tasks

- a. Online
- b. In-store

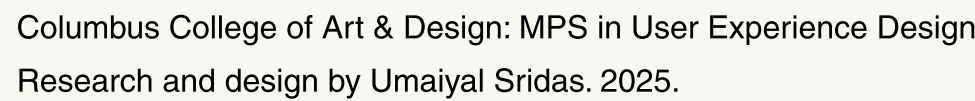
Participants

Age group	Education level	Household income	Have they visited Trader Joe’s at least 3 times this year? (Are they a regular shopper?)	Have they visited the Trader Joe’s website?
18 - 30 years old	PhD or higher	\$25k - \$50k	Yes	No
18 - 30 years old	Master’s degree	\$50k - \$100k	Yes	No
18 - 30 years old	Master’s degree	\$50k - \$100k	Yes	No
18 - 30 years old	Bachelor’s degree	\$100k - \$200k	No	No
31 - 50 years old	Master’s degree	\$100k - \$200k	Yes	No

Data Collection & Key Findings



- Participants **need to supplement Trader Joe's with other grocery stores**, because Trader Joe's doesn't have all they need. They go to other grocery stores due mainly to **proximity** and secondarily to lower **prices**.
- Most participants say part of **the appeal of Trader Joe's is going in person and exploring the aisles**, but one participant **wishes they did have a delivery option**.
- There was **not a large appeal for an app or membership program**.
- **On the website**, participants said **the recipes are unique** and they would take time to explore this. They would like to **be able to add ingredients directly from the recipe**, rather than re-navigating.
- The **snacks, seasonal items, and frozen items are delicious and iconic**, and they have a wide variety.
- The **ingredients** seem to have a **better quality** than other brands and they have a **unique flavor profile**.
- **Produce doesn't seem to be the most fresh** or doesn't last as long as other places.
- **Parking is not good** at most Trader Joe's, due to lack of space and/or the huge crowds.
- Although lines can be long, **checkout generally seems fast**.
- Most participants say the **cashiers are talkative and friendly**, but one participant stated that **some days this is okay, but some days she doesn't have time or energy** to chat.



Maya

AKA the “Snack Seeker”

Bio

Age: 25 years old

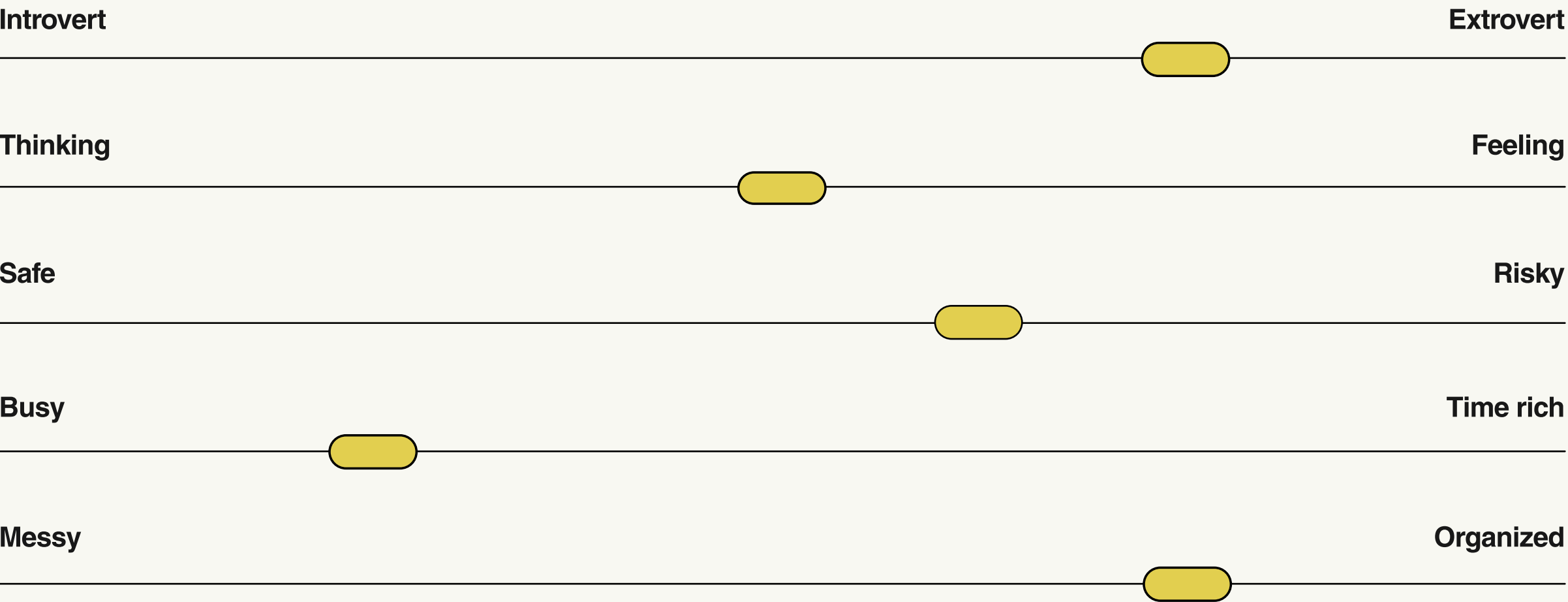
Education level: Master’s degree

Employment: Full-time job

Household: Living alone with long distance partner who comes over occasionally

Maya is a pretty planned person. She is quite busy, but will find time to do her groceries every week on the weekend with the list she has accrued over the week. She does her main shopping at an alternative store, because it will have all the essentials at a lower price, and then follows up with a trip to Trader Joe’s for snacks, seasonal items, and party gifts.

Personality



Maya

AKA the “Snack Seeker”

Goals

Maya goes to Trader Joe’s to get some charcuterie items for parties and some of her favorite/ iconic snacks for herself. She might indulge in a frozen meal, if she feels like it, because Trader Joe’s has some good ones.

Expectations

Maya’s ideal shopping trip: She is not on a time restraint. She has a list made and will visit one grocery store to grab all her items. She knows the route to take to get all of her items, but allows herself time to browse through the snack or seasonal aisles

Actions/Approach

Maya creates a grocery list for her house to go shopping every week. First, she shops at her regular grocery store to get the basic produce and ingredients on her list, but she still wants to get a few fun items. She heads over to Trader Joe’s where she goes aisle by aisle through the whole store and picks out some fun items that catch her eye.

Frustrations

The location and parking of Trader Joe’s is Maya’s worst complaint. Aside from that, she notes that she does almost always need to supplement a Trader Joe’s trip with another grocery store, due to the availability and pricing of basic produce and ingredients.

Maya’s Journey Map

Stage 1	Stage 2	Stage 3			
Motivation	Preparation	Shopping			
1. She needs groceries for the week and is on a budget. 2. She needs a gift for a friend, so she will plan going on the way back home from work. 3. Maybe she will get some snacks for herself.	1. Creates a list of groceries she needs and gifts for her friend.	Stage 3A Regular groceries 1. Drives to convenient and cheaper grocery store. 2. Completes essential groceries.	Stage 3B Commute & Parking 1. Drives to a convenient location. 2. Finds parking a little further away and walks to the store.	Stage 3C Exploration 1. She goes aisle by aisle 2. She knows that wine and charcuterie are great options for gifts. 3. While going through the aisles, she also looks for snacks or seasonal items for herself.	Stage 3D Checkout 1. Stand in line for checkout. 2. Complete checkout at register. 3. Return to car.
“If I'll have a lot of just straight up produce, and I'm on a budget, I'll go to all these [other grocery stores], and then I might stop at Trader Joe's to be like, a couple fun things.”	“I'll make a list for myself on the weekend and get what I can on the weekend, and then if I am not able to because I'm, like, on a town or busy or whatever, then I like fit it in during the week.”	“Sometimes you do need to go to another grocery store. That's kind of a popular assessment of Trader Joe's is they have really good items, but they don't have everything.”	“I will say one of the... negatives of Trader Joe's is I feel like there's always, like, a slightly smaller parking lot, and it's always pretty chaotic in Trader Joe's. It's like, anxiety inducing, but not super inconvenient.”	“I like that it's smaller in that I can walk through every aisle. And every time I go to Trader Joe's, I do walk through every aisle. I feel like part of the vibe of Trader Joe's is that it's like a smaller local grocery store, even though it's definitely not.”	“...that was a fast checkout!”

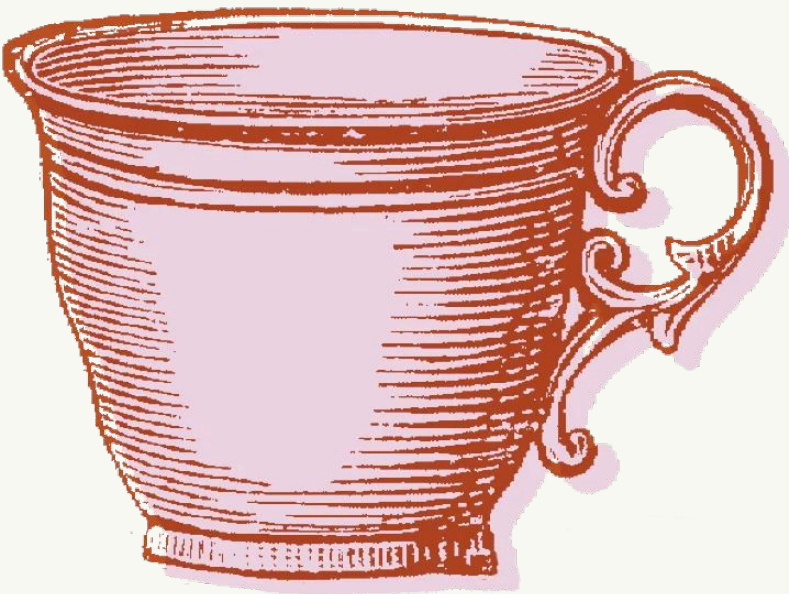
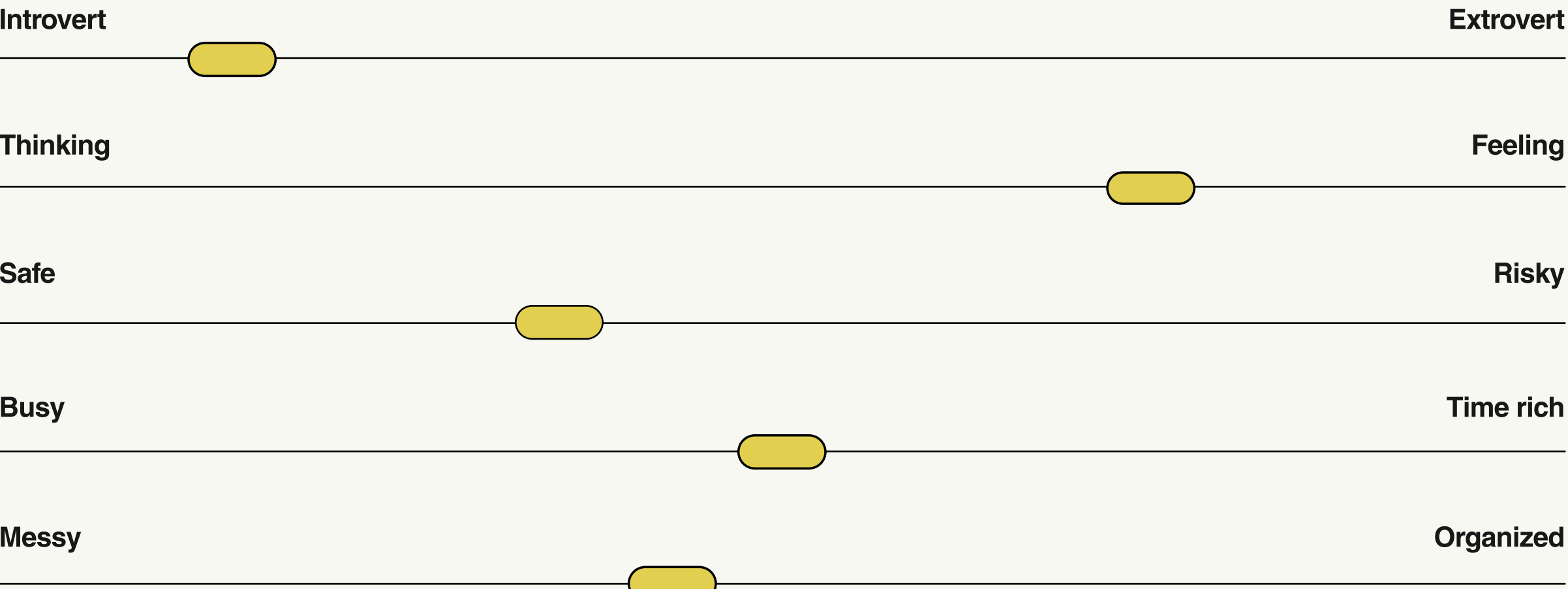
Jess AKA the “Convenience Consumer”

Bio

Age: 32 years old
Education level: Master’s degree
Employment: Full-time job
Household: Living with spouse

Jess is an introvert. She has to interact with people a lot at work and values alone time to do her hobbies. She does a majority of her shopping online, but is interested in certain Trader Joe’s snacks and seasonal items that she sees on social media, so she will go on a day that might be less busy and crowded.

Personality



Jess

AKA the “Convenience Consumer”

Goals

Jess goes to Trader Joe’s for her favorite specialty items and interesting snacks she sees on social media. Her main groceries are delivered to her door, but she can only get certain seasonal items at Trader Joe’s.

Expectations

Jess’s ideal shopping trip:
She stays at home and browses the grocery store website to get her groceries and snacks delivered to her.
OR
She goes to the store during a time where a minimal amount of customers and employees are there. She has a quick checkout with minimal interaction.

Actions/Approach

Jess has a mental list of snacks and specialty items she likes and ones that interested her on social media that she would like to try. She goes aisle by aisle through the whole store, browsing interesting seasonal items, frozen foods, and snacks. Once she gets overwhelmed with the selection, especially without a concrete list, she beelines for the register.

Frustrations

Jess really wishes Trader Joe’s had a delivery or online shopping option, because she does love the snacks and seasonal items, but she doesn’t like being around people in the store. Sometimes chatting with store employees can be a little tiring.

Jess’s Journey Map

Stage 1 Motivation	Stage 2 Preparation	Stage 3 Shopping			Stage 4 Completion
1. Sees some interesting snacks on social media and decides to go on the least busy day of the week. “Generally, I will see things on social media where I'm, like, oh yes, I need to go.” 😊	1. Keeps a mental list of items she liked from social media. 2. Hoping there are not many people. “I think in a perfect world. If no one was there? I would love it! It's mainly there's because there's other people. Yeah. But a whole store to myself, perfect.” 😞	Stage 3A Commute & Parking	Stage 3B Exploration	Stage 3C Checkout	1. Doesn’t like putting groceries away. 2. Doesn’t like cooking. “I like shopping. I do not like going to stores to shop. I used to. But now, I just prefer to do everything online. I like the idea of grocery shopping? It's just like putting them away cooking, like all the other stuff.” 😞
		1. Drives to a convenient location. 2. Finds parking. “Parking, parking?” 😐	1. Goes through aisle by aisle, focusing on seasonal items and snacks. 2. If she finds something that intrigues her, she will ask herself if she really needs it or not before choosing. 3. She gets overwhelmed without a list, so she decided to finish. “I think it's just there's always something to get and like this, but they always have like seasonal items that keeps it like, interesting, and intriguing.” 😊	1. Stand in line for checkout. 2. Complete checkout at register without talking much to the cashier. 3. Return to car. “And the checkout system. I don't love. I feel like it's inefficient for the workers. We don't have like the typical like conveyor belt and thinking as a previous cashier for grocery stores, like it just seems insane... It's just it takes a really long time, and it just it feels like that part of the store is a big bottleneck... And then you're forced to talk with the cashiers. 😞	

Key Opportunities & Recommendations



“

...when I went to the embassy in Bogota [I asked] what is an American food that you want me to bring...? And [they said] we can get kind of everything, but we want Trader Joe's snacks.

”

Aandal

“

I think I just really like that **they have certain specialty items that you cannot get anywhere else.**

”

Shweta



How can Trader Joe's continue to generate excitement around snacks and seasonal items for customers?



“

Sometimes you do need to go to another grocery store. That's kind of a popular assessment of Trader Joe's is **they have really good items, but they don't have everything.**

”

Preston



How can Trader Joe's encourage customers to shop primarily at their store rather than having it as a secondary store which needs a supplement?



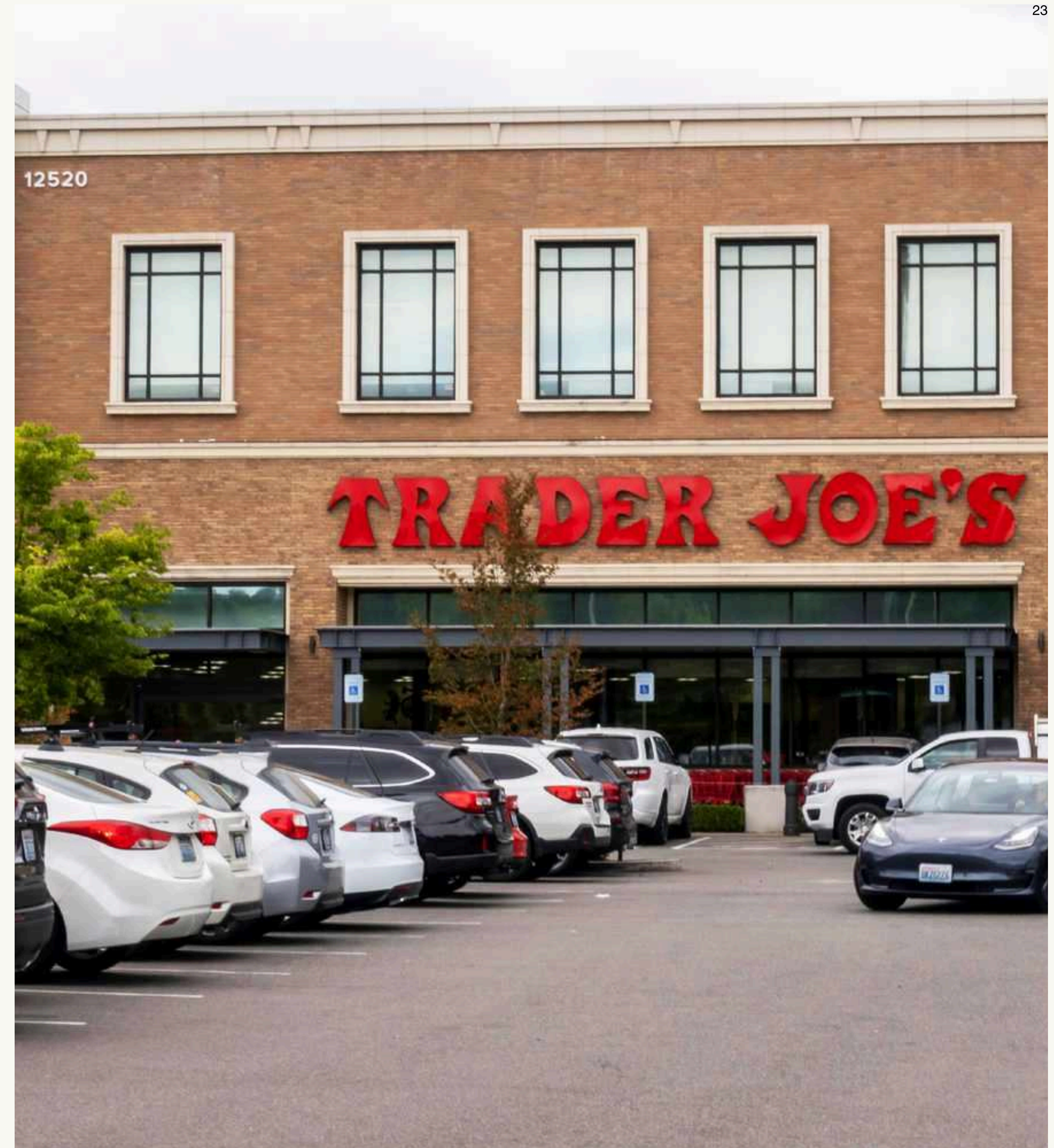
“

I will say **one of the... negatives** of Trader Joe's is I feel like there's always... a slightly **smaller parking lot**, and it's **always pretty chaotic** in Trader Joe's.

”

*Aandal*

How can Trader Joe's make the parking situation less stressful and more accessible?



“

That's another thing I forgot that I don't like about Trader Joe's. Yes, **the lack of delivery.**

”

Paige



How can Trader Joe's cater to customers who may not be able to or would rather not shop in store?

Home > Products > Food > Cheese



Note:

You won't find every Trader Joe's product represented on our website. The best place to go for information about our products and new discoveries! – is your neighborhood Trader Joe's.

What's New

Food

Bakery

Cheese

Slices, Shreds, Crumbles

Wedges, Wheels, Loaves, Logs

Cream and Creamy Cheeses

Dairy & Eggs

Dips, Sauces & Dressings

Fresh Prepared Foods

From The Freezer

Fresh Fruits & Veggies

Meat, Seafood & Plant-based

For the Pantry

Snacks & Sweets

Beverages

Flowers & Plants

Cheese (80)



Slices, Shreds, Crumbles
**Shredded Swiss
Cheese & Gruyère...**

\$4.99/12 Oz

+ ADD TO LIST



Wedges, Wheels, Loaves,...
Fontina

\$6.99/1 Lb

+ ADD TO LIST



“

In terms of finding [the recipe] on the website, super easy. I wish that you could... just immediately add the [ingredients] to your cart. That would be nice.

”



Paige

How can Trader Joe's create a more intuitive ingredient list for customers who are interested in making their recipes?

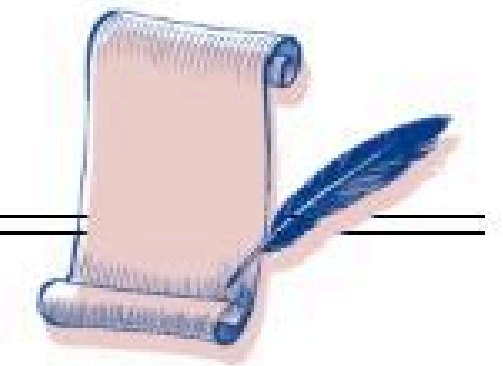
Serves 6-8

Time 1 h 5 mins - 1 h 25 mins



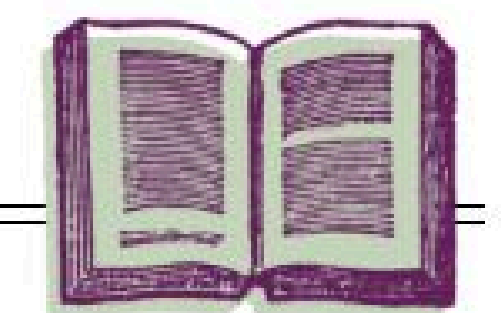
 [Print the Recipe](#)

Ingredients



- 2 packages TJ's Frozen Spinach & Artichoke Dip, microwaved according to directions
- 1/4 cup TJ's Milk
- TJ's Canola Oil Spray
- 2-3 medium-sized TJ's Sweet Potatoes, peeled and sliced into thin rounds
- 1 cup TJ's Quattro Formaggio Shredded Cheese Blend

Directions



1. Preheat oven to 400°F.

Reflection



Reflection

What Went Well

- My video-call recordings went very smoothly and I was able to gather great quotes from the transcripts I extracted. I am happy that I found an app which correctly transcribed my video calls and was able to use some AI features to hone in on specific details that were important.
- Shadowing in store went surprising well and I was able to get a good read on each participant as they walked through the store. I was also lucky to have participants who thoroughly described what they were doing as they shopped. Furthermore, when prompted, they gave full, detailed responses to all my questions.

What Could Be Improved Upon

- Scheduling interviews was complicated due to everyone's different time zones and schedule constraints. In the future, I would try to automate the screening to automatically schedule a time with an eligible participant as soon as they filled out the form, so there is no extra delay of me sifting through screeners.
- Gathering a wide variety of participants was difficult with the time constraint. In the future, I would like to interview people who are not family or friends, or people with a wider range of demographic traits.

Sources

Research Plan, Screener, and Interview Guide

Interview Transcripts and Notes

External Sources:

- Trader Joe's Website
- Chowhound
- The Kitchn
- The Science Survey
- A Comprehensive Analysis of Trader Joe's: Exploration from National and Omaha Metropolitan Perspectives

